



Jungle in flames

A US soldier clears a path through Vietnamese jungle with a flamethrower. In 1978, the US banned the use of flamethrowers in future combat, due to their "indiscriminate" and "excessively injurious" effects.

Agent Orange

The most widely used herbicide in South Vietnam was Agent Orange, named for the orange band on the barrels in which it was stored. It consisted of two chemical herbicides mixed with diesel fuel or kerosene, but also a manufacturing byproduct, Dioxin, considered to be the most toxic molecule synthesized by man. Agent Orange was sprayed liberally by US planes.

The use of herbicides had profound consequences for the Vietnamese. Within two weeks of spraying, leaves would fall from trees or plants, remaining bare until at least the next rainy season. Destroyed crops exacerbated poverty and drove people from their land, contributing to the refugee crisis. The effect of multiple sprayings permanently destroyed vegetation and disrupted animal populations. Dioxin, which is associated with birth defects and diseases, also filtered into the soil. While international law prohibits chemical warfare against people, US courts ruled that Ranch Hand targeted plants, indemnifying the US from liability.

500,000 ACRES The combined area of South Vietnamese farmland sprayed with herbicide to destroy crops that could support the Viet Cong.